

—BOB INGRAM—



SPARKY

# Sparky sees Reds making comeback

GEORGE "Sparky" Anderson had a leisurely breakfast in El Paso Sunday. Between sips of coffee he read the box scores of big league games.

Had the fickle finger of fate been a little more kind, Sparky Anderson on this Sunday would have been having a leisurely breakfast but would have been reading the box scores in Cincinnati instead of El Paso. A few hours later Sparky would have been sending the Red Machine against the San Francisco Giants.

As everyone knows, Sparky was fired by the Cincinnati Reds following the 1978 season. He had managed the Reds nine years and had won two World Series and five National League pennants. He made the mistake of not making the playoffs a year ago.

The reason was easy to see for everybody except the Reds' top executives. Joe Morgan, one of the most valuable of all the Reds, couldn't move around because of a muscle pull. Catcher Johnny Bench missed 54 games. Bill Bonham, counted on to be one of the pitching stars, missed 14 starts.

The injuries to key personnel without a doubt ruined the Reds' chance to beat out the Dodgers for the pennant.

Anderson paid for the misfortunes of the team.

He thinks the Machine has been repaired and predicts that the Reds will bounce back and win the NL even without Pete Rose. And without Sparky Anderson, too.

But he doesn't see any team in baseball beating the New York Yankees in the World Series.

## Box score man

SPARKY, HERE for Jim Paul's meeting of the "El Paso 50" and a clinic at Dudley Field, confessed that he seldom read anything in newspapers except the box scores.

His reasons: The importance of some players is overblown and the modern school of writers tends to go to "Rip City."

He doesn't care to read their comments.

If he's not an avid newspaper reader, why is he such a friend of the writers?

"I know they have a job to do," he said, "so I try to help them as much as possible."

Then he went on to say he figured sports writers had done a lot toward "making sports," and that the writers make a bigger impact in baseball than the electronic media.

So, Sparky, all is forgiven.

The friendly Californian hopes to return to managing next season. He will, in effect, take a job "if

it's the right one" this season. "There'll be five or six managers fired this year," he predicted as a matter of course.

He called Pete Rose at Cincinnati "the Animal," claiming that he is the toughest competitor he has ever seen. "The only thing that will stop him will be his reflexes. If you take him out of the lineup, you'd have to fight him."

Anderson was known as "Captain Hook" at Cincinnati for his habit of jerking pitchers quickly. "We had a good bullpen," was one of his explanations.

## Weaver 'smartest'

HE LOOKS ON Branch Rickey, who established the farm system and broke baseball's color line, as the patron saint of baseball, saying, "He was far ahead of his day in baseball."

Earl Weaver, he considers, to be the smartest manager in baseball. "If I was a club owner I'd go get Weaver for a manager," he says.

He credits Gene Mauch with being an astute manager, too.

Sparky doesn't believe in having team meetings before games except on rare occasions. "If you have them too often you lose your effectiveness in some ways. I prefer the one-on-one system."

The clean-shaven Cincinnati players are brought up from the club's farm system to have a high regard for dress and conduct.

The only dissension the Reds had under him was a minor quarrel between two natives of the Dominican Republic, Pedro Borbon and Cesar Geronimo. It was patched up and the players continued to room with each other.

The super scout system, "which we started," is followed in baseball today. One scout of a big league club stays one series ahead to watch the opposing team play. There's very little the scout misses.

"There isn't anybody in baseball who doesn't know Andy Cohen or doesn't know of him."

Sparky won't wear his World Series rings because "so many other people helped me that they deserve to wear them."

He was a non-distinguished second baseman for the Phillies in 1958. Good field, no hit.

That was the extent of his big league playing. After he had managed a few minor league clubs and was made a coach on the San Diego team, he was named manager of the Cincinnati Reds.

"Sparky Who?" asked the Cincy fans.

Everybody knows Sparky now.